

Yağmur Deniz Kısa

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Department of Comparative Cultural Psychology
Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology
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Employment

2025-2027	Humboldt Research Fellow Department of Comparative Cultural Psychology Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology, Leipzig, Germany
2022-present	Postdoctoral Researcher Department of Comparative Cultural Psychology Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology, Leipzig, Germany
2017-2022	PhD student Department of Psychology University of Chicago, IL, USA

Education

2017-2022	Ph.D. in Psychology University of Chicago, IL, USA Advisors: Susan Goldin-Meadow and Daniel Casasanto
2011-2017	B.A. in Psychology & Philosophy Koç University, Istanbul, Turkey

Publications

- Kısa, Y. D.**, Stengelin, R. & Haun, D.B.M. (under review). Egocentric thinking before egocentric language in early childhood.
- Kısa, Y. D.**, Stengelin, R., Maurits, L. & Haun, D.B.M. (2026). Cognitive change without linguistic change: The rise of egocentric frames of reference in the Hai||om. *Cognition*, 273, 106522.
- Kısa, Y. D.**, Goldin-Meadow, S., & Casasanto, D. (2024). Gesturing during disfluent speech: A pragmatic account. *Cognition*, 250, 105855.
- Kısa, Y. D.**, Goldin-Meadow, S., & Casasanto, D. (2022). Do gestures really facilitate speech production? *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*. 151(6), 1252–1271.
<https://doi.org/10.1037/xge0001135>.
- Kısa Y.D.**, Goldin-Meadow, S. & Casasanto, D. (2021). Do gestures really facilitate speech production? In *Proceedings of the 43rd Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society*, 43.
- Karşılar, H., **Kısa, Y.D.** & Balcı, F. (2018). Dilation and constriction of subjective time based on observed walking speed. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 9, 2565. doi: 10.3389/fpsyg.2018.02565.
- Kısa, Y. D.**, Aktan-Erciyes, A., Turan, E. & Göksun, T. (2018). Parental use of spatial language and gestures in early childhood. *British Journal of Developmental Psychology*, 37, 149-167.

Invited talks

- 2026 "The cultural origins of egocentric thinking in children."
Language and Cognition Lab Meeting, Koç University, Turkey
- 2024 "A communicative account of gesturing when speaking is difficult."
Language and Learning Group Seminar, University of Warwick, UK
"How do humans become egocentric spatial thinkers?"
The Center for Research in Cognition and Neurosciences, Belgium
- 2022 "Do gestures really facilitate speech production?"
Language and Cognitive Development Lab, Middle East Technical University, Turkey
- 2021 "The nature and origins of spatial thinking"
Dep.of Comparative Cultural Psychology, MPI for Evolutionary Anthropology, Germany
"Moving hands during acting and thinking: Origins of gestures during mental abacus"
Center for Gesture, Sign and Language Research, USA
- 2019 "Chunking in gesture can facilitate mental abacus problem solving"
Dep.of Psychology Developmental Brownbag, University of Chicago, USA

Conference presentations

- Kısa Y.D., Stengelin, R. & Haun. D. B. M. (2026, January). The cultural origins of egocentric thinking in children. Paper presented at the 16th Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development, Budapest, Hungary.
- Kısa Y.D., Stengelin, R., Maurits, L. & Haun. D. B. M. (2024, July). Is magnetoreception experience-dependent in humans? Poster presented at the 46th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society, Rotterdam, Netherlands.
- Kısa Y.D., Stengelin, R. & Haun. D. B. M. (2024, May). Historical origins of diversity in spatial cognition: Evidence against the Whorfian view from #Akhoe Hai||om speakers. Poster presented at the 15th Dubrovnik Conference on Cognitive Science, Dubrovnik, Croatia.
- Kısa Y.D., Achen, C., Goldin-Meadow, S. & Casasanto, D. (2022, July). Why do people gesture more during disfluent speech? A pragmatic account. Poster presented at the 44th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society.
- Kısa Y.D., Goldin-Meadow, S. & Casasanto, D. (2022, July). Do gestures really facilitate speech production? 9th Conference of the International Society for Gesture Studies, Chicago, IL.
- Kısa Y.D., Achen, C., Goldin-Meadow, S. & Casasanto, D. (2022, July). Why do people gesture more during disfluent speech? A pragmatic account. 9th Conference of the International Society for Gesture Studies, Chicago, IL.
- Kısa Y.D., Goldin-Meadow, S. & Casasanto, D. (2021, July). Do gestures really facilitate speech production? Paper presented at the 43rd Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society.
- Kısa Y.D., Achen, C., Goldin-Meadow, S. & Casasanto, D. (2021, May). Pragmatic function of gestures. Paper presented at the 2021 APS Virtual Convention.

- Bergey, C. A., Kisa Y.D., Casasanto, D. & Yurovsky, D. (2020, July). Where does the conceptual space–time asymmetry come from? Poster presented at the 42nd Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society.
- Kisa Y.D., Goldin-Meadow, S. & Casasanto, D. (2020, June-September). Do gestures facilitate speech production? Poster presented at the Association for Psychological Science Poster Showcase.
- Casasanto, D. & Kisa, Y. D. (2019, July). Origins of cross-domain asymmetries. Poster presented at the 41st Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society, Montreal, Quebec, Canada.
- Casasanto, D. & Kisa, Y. D. (2019, May). Origins of cross-domain asymmetries. Poster presented at the 31th annual convention of the Association for Psychological Science, Washington, D.C.
- Kisa, Y. D., Brooks, N. B. & Goldin-Meadow, S. (2018, July). Chunking in gesture can facilitate mental abacus problem solving. 8th Conference of the International Society for Gesture Studies: Gesture and Diversity, Cape Town, South Africa.
- Sarıçimen, İ., Kisa, Y. D., Aktan-Erciyes, A., & Göksun, T. (2017, July). Mothers' use of spatial language and spatial gestures. 14th International Congress for the Study of Child Language, Lyon, France.
- Kisa, Y.D., Sarıçimen, İ., Aktan-Erciyes, A., & Göksun, T. (2017, April). Learning relational words: A longitudinal study. Paper presented as part of the symposium in N. George (chair), Playing with words: How parents highlight event structure through language and gesture, at the Society for Research on Child Development, Austin, TX.
- Kisa, Y. D., Aktan-Erciyes, A., & Göksun, T. (2017, January). A longitudinal study on learning spatial language in the first two years. Poster presented at the 7th Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development, Budapest, Hungary.
- Kisa, Y.D., Karşilar, H. & Balci, F. (2015, December). The effect of biological motion on time perception. Poster presented at the Department of Psychology, Koç University, Istanbul, Turkey.

Funding

2025-2027	Alexander von Humboldt Foundation, Humboldt Research Fellowship
2021	Center for International Social Science Research Lloyd and Susanne Rudolph Field Research Award
2020	Center for Gesture, Sign and Language Research Grant
2020	Center for Latin American Studies Mellon Research Travel Fellowship Award
2018	Center for Gesture, Sign and Language Research Grant
2017-2022	University of Chicago Social Sciences Fellowship
2017-2019	Fulbright Scholarship for Doctoral studies [Declined]

Fieldwork

2023 – present	Cross-cultural and developmental psychology research in Namibia among Hai om and Khwe communities
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Teaching

Spring 2024	Leipzig University, Germany Session in seminar (Psychology): Language and thought
Fall 2024	University of Namibia, Namibia

	Workshop (Psychology and Social Work): Cross-Cultural Developmental Psychology
Spring 2023	Leipzig University, Germany
	Session in seminar (Early childhood research): Spatial cognition
Fall 2021	University of Chicago, USA
	Lab sessions in seminar (Psychology): Psychological Research Methods
Spring 2021	University of Chicago, USA
	Discussion sessions in seminar (Psychology): Cognitive Psychology
Spring 2020	University of Chicago, USA
	Discussion sessions in seminar (Psychology): Cognitive Psychology
	Discussion sessions in seminar (Psychology): Developmental Psychology
Winter 2020	University of Chicago, USA
	Discussion sessions in seminar (Psychology & Neuroscience): Biological Psychology
	Guest lecture (Psychology & Neuroscience): Topographical disorientation

Reviewer

Journal of Experimental Psychology: General; Developmental Science; Child Development; Journal of Experimental Psychology: Learning, Memory, and Cognition; PLOS One; Gesture; Journal of Cognitive Neuroscience; Journal of Cognitive Psychology; Spatial Cognition and Computation: An Interdisciplinary Journal